Winner of 29 Pulitzer Prizes for Excellence in Journalism

Chicago Tribune

$4.00 | SATURDAY, OCTOBER 31, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Pope Leo casts local mail-in ballot

Dolton native, registered as a Will County voter, makes history as 1st pontiff to vote in US election

By Angie Leventis Lourgos and Michelle Mullins
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Chicago native Pope Leo XIV has cast a local mail-in ballot ahead of the November midterms, making history as the first pontiff to vote in a U.S. election.

The Vatican announced Friday that Leo, who remains an American citizen, has submitted a mail-in ballot, citing his commitment to civic participation.

"The Holy Father expresses his belief in the right and the duty of citizens to participate in democratic processes," the Holy See said in a statement.

The pope — formerly Robert Prevost — is registered as a Will County voter in New Lenox, where his brother, John Prevost, lives.

The pope made an online request for a mail-in ballot to be sent to a New Lenox address on Oct. 3, said Kimberly Fladhammer, chief of staff for the Will County clerk's office.

"It is historic," Fladhammer added.

The returned ballot was not yet received as of Friday afternoon, she said.

Will County Clerk Annette Parker said she was proud to be the county clerk for the momentous occasion.

"I'm happy he is participating in the voting process just as every eligible person should," Parker said. "It's exciting."

The clerk's office can track the ballot through its computer software, but Fladhammer and Parker said they may not be able to catch it the moment it is processed. If a staff member recognizes the pope's name as they go through the mail-in ballots, those in the room might want to touch it to receive a blessing, Parker added.

Chicago Cardinal Blase Cupich said he hopes the pope's example "encourages everybody to get out and vote."

"He believes in the power of democracy," Cupich said, adding that the pontiff's participation in local elections shows "his affection for the place he grew up in and that formed him."

By voting, the Holy Father is setting an example for the Catholic faithful on civic responsibility, said Christopher White, associate direc-

See **POPE** on Page A4

ELECTION 2026

Trump itinerary adds back 2 rallies

President returning to Iowa, Kansas; US sees early-vote spike

By Michelle L. Price, Seung Min Kim and Joey Cappelletti
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — As early voting surges across the country, President Donald Trump is reshuffling his weekend schedule to rally Republicans in two states with critical Senate races, underscoring his party's push to drive turnout ahead of Election Day.

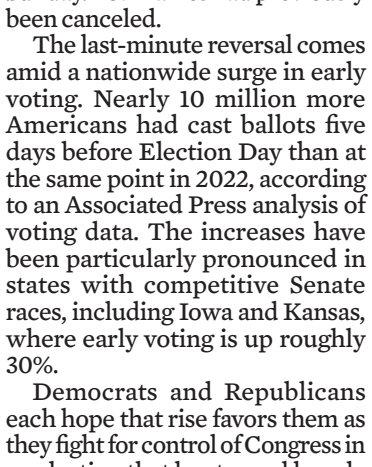
The Republican president will now visit Iowa and Kansas for back-to-back campaign rallies on Sunday. Both rallies had previously been canceled.

The last-minute reversal comes amid a nationwide surge in early voting. Nearly 10 million more Americans had cast ballots five days before Election Day than at the same point in 2022, according to an Associated Press analysis of voting data. The increases have been particularly pronounced in states with competitive Senate races, including Iowa and Kansas, where early voting is up roughly 30%.

Democrats and Republicans each hope that rise favors them as they fight for control of Congress in an election that has turned largely on affordability issues and the president's unpopularity. At the start of the month, Trump promised a marathon sprint of his signature rallies to shore up Republican candidates, and he has headlined 25 of them so far in October.

The president on Thursday furiously pushed back at the notion that the initial cancellation of his Kansas rally, which became public as he was returning to Washing-

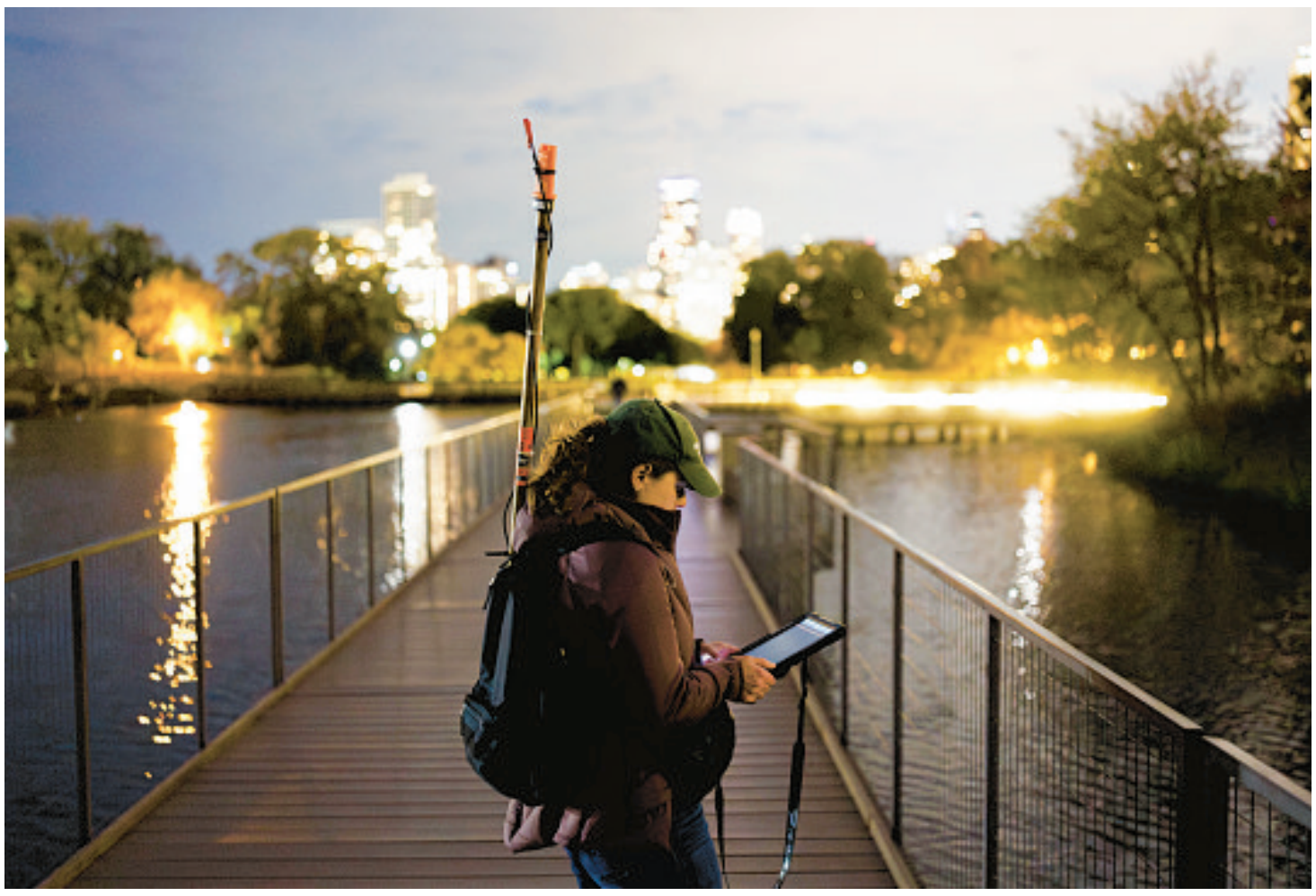
See **ELECTION** on Page A6



TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/ CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Simmons has first practice with Bears

Newly acquired All-Pro defensive tackle says trade from Titans to Bears is "a blessing" but comes with a lot of emotions as he practices for the first time at Halas Hall. **Sports**



Liza Lehrer, assistant director at Lincoln Park Zoo's Urban Wildlife Institute, carries a backpack with an Echo Meter Touch 2 Pro Bat Detector on the end of a pole while looking for the ultrasonic echolocation emitted by bats in Lincoln Park on Monday. **ARMANDO L. SANCHEZ/TRIBUNE**

Surveys boost interest in bat protection efforts

Populations in Illinois declining amid spread of white-nose syndrome



A northern long-eared bat. **WISCONSIN DEPARTMENT OF NATURAL RESOURCES**

By Jerry Wu
FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The sun had already gone down as Liza Lehrer began her stroll around the nature boardwalk at Lincoln Park Zoo.

As she passed through the tallgrass prairie, she heard the ducks' soft quacking, the wind whistling in the air. A few feet ahead, a chipmunk scurried past before darting into the bushes. But Lehrer's attention was somewhere else.

A pole wrapped in a long wire stuck out of the small backpack she was carrying, a tiny microphone at the tip. Not just any microphone — one that detected ultrasonic echolocation calls in the air, beyond human hearing.

In her hands was an iPad connected to the microphone. She glanced eagerly at the screen to see if a familiar bundle of colorful lines, representing calls above 20 kilohertz, would appear.

That would mean a bat was close.

As Chicago temperatures begin to drop in October, Lehrer, who's the assistant director at Lincoln Park Zoo's Urban Wildlife Institute, was wrapping up one of the last bat survey walks of the season. She hoped to record at least one bat.

While eight different species have been spotted in Chicago, Lehrer said that the tricolored, little brown and northern long-eared bats have been increasingly harder to find. Those three species have seen their numbers dwindle over the past years because of white-nose syndrome, a devastating fungal disease that has wiped out hibernating bats.

The U.S. Fish and Wildlife

See **BATS** on Page A2

A hoops road trip of biblical proportions

How Notre Dame's game vs. Villanova in Rome, and potential meeting with pope, came about

By Colleen Kane
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

When Notre Dame women's basketball coach Niele Ivey first heard the idea, she was thrilled.

With the election of Pope Leo XIV as inspiration, college sports event organizers wanted to host a pair of men's and women's basketball games in Rome. Villanova, the pope's alma mater, would occupy one bench. Notre Dame, another of the United States' prominent Catholic universities — only about 80 miles from where the pope grew up in Dolton — would be on the opposing side.

Ivey had taken her team to Paris in 2023 to play a season-opening game. She knew an international game could be special for her players, some of whom never had left the country.

She also believed her team — ranked No. 13 in the Associated Press poll to open the season and led by senior guard Hannah Hidalgo, one of the nation's best players — deserved the big stage that comes with the event, which takes place a day before the rest of the college basketball season opens.

See **GAME** on Page A2



Notre Dame coach Niele Ivey hugs KK Bransford as they celebrate a 67-64 victory against Vanderbilt in the Sweet 16 of the NCAA Tournament on March 27 in Fort Worth, Texas. **ELSA/GETTY**

SUBSCRIPTION

Visit myaccount.chicagotribune.com or call 312-546-7900 to sign up for a subscription. To place an ad, visit placeanad.chicagotribune.com.

WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY	MON.	TUE.
H:66 L: 56	H:64 L: 61	H:70 L: 58

FULL WEATHER REPORT A8

INDEX

Almanac A6
Arts & Living B7
Comics B10-B11
Crossword B11
Editorials A5
Horoscope B10
Nation & World B4
Obituaries A6
Television B9

179th year No. 304
© Chicago Tribune